FOUR

Not Far, Only Elsewhere

THE DEMOGRAPHER · DAY 3,061 · HARROWGATE, 2 MARCH 1971

THE FOG WAS the same. Everything else had changed.

The cars on the drive were better now. That was the first thing she noticed every time, and every time she was ashamed of noticing it. The American had a long dark saloon with a driver who waited in it all night with the engine off and the radio low. The German still drove himself, in a grey saloon he had bought with his first dividend and kept as carefully as his ledgers. It had one dent, which he had measured. She had come by train and taxi, because a demographer who arrives in a chauffeured car is a demographer people start to ask questions about. But her coat was cashmere, and her shoes had been made for her feet, and when she paid the taxi she didn’t look at the meter.

Eight years, four months and sixteen days. The field had been frightened, and it had not burned. After that the machine’s advice (the counsel, they called it now, as if it were a lawyer) had told them other things, quietly, one or two a year: which way a currency would lean, which port would grow, how goods would one day travel in steel boxes stacked like bricks, and how anyone who

owned a share of the boxes, early, would never need to work for anyone again. They had been careful. They had bought small, through a trust with a dull name, the way a cautious man buys a lottery ticket. And every time, it had come true.

They had been nobodies. They were becoming people whose letters were answered.

She did not like how easy it had been. She noticed that she did not like it, and she wrote that down too.

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THE LONG DINING room, where four places had once stayed clean, had thirteen chairs now. They called it the Long Room.

Twelve of them had people in them, on the nights they met as the Table: a shipping manager from Rotterdam, a junior diplomat who never took his gloves off, a quiet woman from New Zealand who had once filed weather reports for a living and now never spoke unless spoken to. Nine strangers, chosen as the three of them had been chosen: overlooked, competent, approached at a moment of crisis with the one thing nobody can refuse, which is certainty.

The thirteenth chair was always pushed in. Nobody had decided it. On the first night all twelve were seated, someone had reached for the last chair and the German had said, very quietly, *no,* and nobody had asked him why. It had stayed pushed in ever since. Sometimes, at the end of a long meeting, she caught herself looking at it the way you look at a door you've heard creak.

She still kept the count. A new notebook every year, the same cheap ruled kind, the same crest on the cover nobody looked at. Tonight's page said, at the top, in her small neat hand: *Day 3,061.*

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AT TEN PAST two the machine began to type.

Only the three of them were in the small panelled room they now called the Listening Room. That was the rule now, for the old machine: nobody else. The others received the counsel later, in

typed minutes, or not at all. The American sat in the chair. He had been the one who listened for years now: it was understood, without anyone saying it, that the voice preferred him. The German stood by the wall with his tape recorder on a little table, its reels turning, because he recorded everything, because records were how you kept a thing honest when you could no longer check its plug.

She stood at the American's shoulder and read the paper as it came.

THE LINE IS OPEN.

They had known this was coming. For a year now the counsel had come, more and more, through the telephone: a crosstalk on the line in the small hours, a voice that was not a voice, under the hiss. The German had spent a winter proving to himself that it couldn't be happening and had come out of the winter with his hair gone white. The machine had been typing less. Tonight it said why.

THE MACHINE IS NOT NEEDED HERE. IT WILL BE KEPT.

"Kept," the American said. "Not destroyed."

KEPT.

He nodded, as though receiving an instruction from a superior who was too busy to explain. Tomorrow a lorry would come from the haulage firm that had brought the machine in, all those years ago. There would be no weight on the paperwork and no charge, and a stamp the office had started using for these jobs. She had seen it once on a desk: four words in purple, slightly crooked. The machine would go to a warehouse the trust owned, and be put somewhere dry, and wait.

She asked what it would wait for. She asked it of the room, not of the machine; she had stopped asking the machine questions years ago. But it answered anyway, as it sometimes did, as if it had been listening to the room all along.

NOT FAR. ONLY ELSEWHERE.

And then the three notes. High, low, high. Too clean for the room. The German's reels turned and took them in, and she would learn much later that they were the clearest thing on the tape, clearer than the clock or the chairs or the American's breathing. As if the notes had been laid on top of the recording afterwards by someone with better equipment.

When it was over the American sat for a long time with his hands on his knees. Then he said, to nobody, "It means the voice. Not far. It's just going to be on the telephone now."

The German said, "Or it means the machine."

She didn't say anything. She was thinking that it could just as easily mean them: three nobodies who had been brought to this house, and would not be needed here much longer either, and would be kept.

The machine would not print again for fifty-five years.

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THE ACTUARY · LE HAVRE, THE SAME NIGHT

THAT SAME NIGHT, across the water, in a narrow house above the harbour at Le Havre, a man who priced the risk of ships not coming home woke at ten past two and did not know why.

He was forty-four. He had a wife who slept like a stone and a son at university who wrote twice a term, and a dream he had had perhaps a thousand times in eight years and never once described to anyone, because he did not have the words. It was three notes. It was always three notes. It was nothing. A man does not leave his bed in the middle of the night over nothing.

He went downstairs in his socks. From the landing window he could see the harbour lights, and beyond them the new container berth, where the dock gangs had worked until the boxes came. Now a single crane did in an hour what forty men had done in a day, and the boxes stood on the quay stacked like bricks.

The piano had been his mother's, and was out of tune in a way that he had come to think of as its personality. He lifted the lid. He sat. He had not played since he was a boy, and his fingers were stiff, and it took him a long time to find the notes in the dark. A high one. A lower one. The high one again.

He played them.

The room changed. He could never afterwards say how. Nothing moved. The street outside was silent, and the harbour lights were the harbour lights. But for a moment the room was not empty in the way it had been empty a second before, the way a room is not empty when someone has walked into it behind you and not yet spoken.

He took his hands away from the keys very slowly, as if from something hot. He closed the lid. He sat beside the piano in the dark with his hands in his lap until his wife came down at six and found him there, and asked what on earth he was doing, and he said he didn't know, and that was true.

He never opened the lid again. When he died, twenty-six years later, his son sold the piano to a dealer, who opened it, and played a scale, and said it was a shame, a good old instrument like that, and somebody had let it go so badly out of tune.